Topic: Resource Allocation and Performance Support

Author Name: Higher Education

Article: Mattookkaran, S. S., Mestre, T., Shortt, B., & Martin, F. (2020). *The HPT model applied to a university technology and learning center's resource allocation*.

Introduction

The article by Mattookkaran, Mestre, Shortt, and Martin (2020) presents a case study from a southeastern university that illustrates how Human Performance Technology (HPT) can be applied to improve organizational efficiency in higher education. The Technology and Learning Center (TLC), part of the university's Information and Technology Services, was responsible for supporting faculty and students with both technical and instructional needs. Despite its mission, the center was struggling with delayed ticket resolutions, unclear workflows, and dissatisfaction among stakeholders.

Graduate students in instructional systems technology were engaged as consultants to analyze the situation and recommend solutions. They applied the HPT model, which is a systematic framework for performance improvement. The model emphasizes identifying performance gaps, analyzing their causes, and designing interventions that fit the organizational context. More information about the model can be found through the International Society for Performance Improvement's HPT framework.

The theoretical foundation for this case connects directly to instructional design literature. Reiser and Dempsey (2018) explain that instructional design today extends beyond content creation to include organizational systems and performance improvement. Robinson and Robinson (2008) emphasize that performance consulting requires close collaboration with stakeholders to uncover the real causes of problems and align solutions with institutional goals. These perspectives help explain why the consulting team did not simply recommend additional training but instead focused on redesigning workflows, clarifying roles, and improving communication. The TLC case demonstrates how instructional design and performance consulting intersect to create meaningful organizational change in higher education.

Case Overview

The Technology and Learning Center is a unit within the university's Information and Technology Services department. It is divided into two teams: the Technical Team, which manages Tier 2 service desk tickets, and the Instructional Programs Team, which provides support for more complex, pedagogy-related issues. Together, these teams are responsible for ensuring that faculty and students receive timely and effective support for teaching and learning technologies.

At the time of the case, the TLC was experiencing significant operational inefficiencies. Support tickets were delayed, communication between teams was inconsistent, and faculty members were dissatisfied with the level of service. Staff members were unclear about their responsibilities, and workflows lacked prioritization. These problems revealed a gap between the center's mission and its daily operations. Faculty needed reliable support to deliver courses effectively, but the existing system was not meeting those needs.

Stakeholder interviews and data reviews confirmed that the issues were not caused by lack of effort but by systemic misalignments. Faculty expressed frustration with slow responses, while staff struggled with unclear role definitions. Administrators wanted better accountability and more effective use of resources. The consulting team of graduate students was tasked with investigating these problems and recommending solutions. Guided by the HPT model, they conducted organizational, environmental, gap, and cause analyses. This systematic approach allowed them to identify the root causes of inefficiencies and prepare recommendations that aligned with both the TLC's mission and the university's broader goals.

Solutions Implemented

The consulting team applied the HPT model step by step. They began with stakeholder interviews and reviewed existing data to help the environment. Then they conducted organizational, environmental, gaps, and cause analyses. This process helped them identify that the ticketing workflow lacked clarity and prioritization.

To address these issues, the consulting team redesigned the ticketing workflow to improve clarity and prioritization. Tickets were categorized more clearly, escalation procedures were established, and responsibilities were defined for both the Technical Team and the Instructional Programs Team. Performance support

tools were also introduced to help staff manage tasks more effectively. These changes addressed the root causes of delays and confusion rather than simply adding more training.

These solutions reflected the principles of HPT, which emphasize using both instructional and non-instructional strategies to improve performance. As Reiser and Dempsey (2018) note, instructional designers must consider environmental factors and organizational systems when designing solutions. Robinson and Robinson (2008) reinforce that performance consulting often requires changes to processes, tools, and communication. The TLC case demonstrated these principles in practice, showing how systemic redesign can resolve operational inefficiencies.

Outcomes

The interventions produced measurable improvements in the center's operations. Response times improved significantly, and faculty and staff reported greater satisfaction with the support they received. Staff members gained a clearer understanding of their roles, which reduced confusion and improved accountability. The workflow became more streamlined, allowing the center to handle requests more efficiently and consistently.

Beyond these operational improvements, the case also highlighted an important cultural shift. Team members began to see their work not just as isolated tasks but as part of a larger institutional mission. This change in perspective helped align the center's operations with its strategic goals and created a stronger sense of purpose among staff.

No major failures were reported, which suggests that the solutions were well-targeted and effective. The outcomes reinforced the idea that performance issues are often systemic and require thoughtful, evidence-based approaches to resolve. By applying the HPT model, the consulting team was able to create sustainable improvements that benefited both staff and stakeholders.

Implications

The implications of this case extend beyond the Technology and Learning Center. It demonstrates the value of applying the HPT model in higher education settings to diagnose systemic issues and design solutions that align with organizational goals. Instructional designers, when acting as performance consultants, can play

a strategic role in organizational development by looking beyond content creation to consider processes, resources, and communication systems.

As Robinson and Robinson (2008) emphasize, performance consulting is about enabling people and systems to perform better. The TLC case showed that listening to stakeholders, mapping workflows, and designing context-sensitive interventions are essential steps in any consulting project. Reiser and Dempsey (2018) further support the idea that instructional design is evolving to include performance improvement and organizational alignment.

This case also illustrates the importance of involving external consultants, even graduate students, who can bring fresh perspectives and apply structured frameworks to diagnose problems. It reinforces the belief that effective consulting requires a blend of analytical skills, empathy, and strategic thinking. For instructional designers, this means developing the ability to look beyond training to consider the broader systems that influence performance.

References

Mattookkaran, S. S., Mestre, T., Shortt, B., & Martin, F. (2020). *The HPT model applied to a university technology and learning center's resource allocation*. In *Cases on learning design and human performance technology* (pp. 42–57). IGI Global.

Reiser, R. A., & Dempsey, J. V. (2018). *Trends and issues in instructional design and technology* (4th ed.). Pearson.

Robinson, D. G., & Robinson, J. C. (2008). *Performance consulting: A practical guide for HR and learning professionals*. Berrett-Koehler Publishers.